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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

EDU 101: Foundations of Education - Purpose, History and Practice

What education is for, and how schools actually work

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Education
Educational Foundations | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Education students often memorise definitions without understanding the debates underneath them. This pack covers the meaning and aims of education, major philosophies, the Nigerian education system and the basics of curriculum and assessment.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish education, schooling and indoctrination.
- Compare major educational philosophies and their classroom implications.
- Describe the structure and levels of the Nigerian education system.
- Explain curriculum, pedagogy and assessment as connected decisions.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What education is

Education is a deliberate process of developing knowledge, skills, attitudes and values. Schooling is one institution through which it happens.

- Formal education is structured and certified; informal education is embedded in daily life; non-formal education is organised but flexible.
- Indoctrination closes inquiry; education opens it. The distinction lies in method and intent.
- Aims include intellectual development, social efficiency, citizenship, moral development and self-actualisation.
- Education is both a right and an instrument of national development.
- Nigerian policy defines basic education broadly, including junior secondary.
- Teachers exercise authority, which makes ethical self-awareness essential.

Educational philosophies

Philosophy answers what knowledge is and what teaching should therefore look like.

- Idealism: emphasises ideas and moral formation; teacher as model.
- Realism: emphasises observation and the natural order.
- Pragmatism and progressivism: learning through experience and problem solving; teacher as facilitator.
- Essentialism: core knowledge and discipline transmitted systematically.
- Constructivism: learners build understanding from prior knowledge and activity.
- Perennialism: enduring ideas and canonical texts.

> **Theory to classroom**
> Examiners love the question 'what does this mean for teaching practice?' Always move from the philosophy to a concrete classroom behaviour.

System, curriculum and assessment

Curriculum is what is intended to be learned; instruction is how it is taught; assessment is how we know whether it was learned.

- Nigerian structure: early childhood, nine years of basic education, three years of senior secondary, then tertiary.
- A curriculum includes objectives, content, methods and evaluation.
- Bloom's taxonomy orders cognitive objectives from remembering to creating.
- Assessment types: diagnostic, formative and summative.
- Valid assessment measures what it claims; reliable assessment is consistent.
- Continuous assessment reduces the weight of a single examination and provides feedback.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish education from indoctrination.

Answer: Education develops the ability to question and reason; indoctrination instils beliefs while suppressing critical examination.

2. What is the difference between formal and non-formal education?

Answer: Formal education follows a structured curriculum in institutions and leads to certification. Non-formal education is organised learning outside the formal system, such as adult literacy classes.

3. State one classroom implication of constructivism.

Answer: Teaching should begin from learners' prior knowledge and use activities or problems that require them to build new understanding.

4. Differentiate formative from summative assessment.

Answer: Formative assessment occurs during learning to guide improvement; summative assessment occurs at the end to judge achievement.

5. List two aims of education.

Answer: Intellectual development and preparation for responsible citizenship.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write your own definition of education and defend it in three sentences.
- [ ] Compare three educational philosophies in a table.
- [ ] Draw the structure of the Nigerian education system.
- [ ] List the components of a curriculum.
- [ ] Classify five assessment tasks as diagnostic, formative or summative.
- [ ] Explain validity and reliability with an example each.
- [ ] Observe a lesson and identify the dominant teaching approach.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: